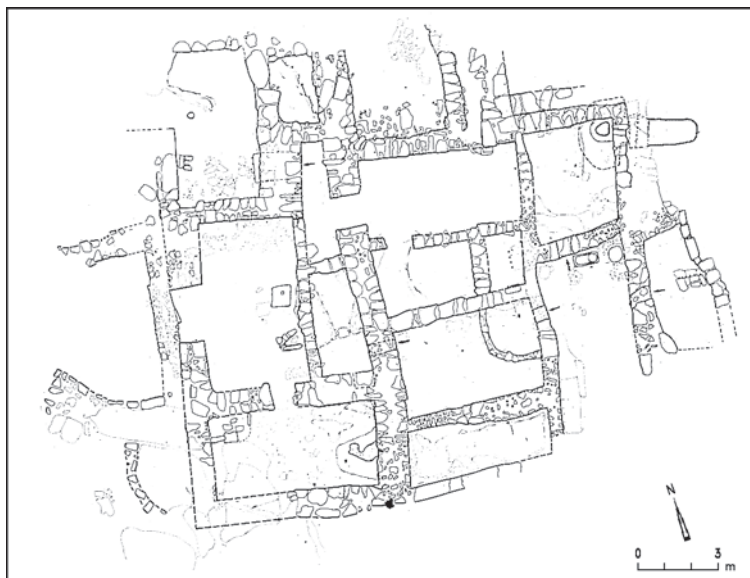




Jebel Nimra: plan of the Persian period building.

plaster on this floor and upon the walls indicate that it served as a pool. It yielded a large quantity of loom weights and oil lamps with high bases. Water was supplied to the building from a rock-cut cistern on the northern side; the cistern has remained in use to present.

The entrance to the four rooms in the center of the building was not found, although there was a doorway connecting the two rooms on the northern side and another doorway leading into a narrow room on the west. Large quantities of pottery uncovered in these rooms indicate that they probably served as storerooms. In the third room in this row was an installation in the shape of a quarter circle, built of undressed stones and preserved to a height of 0.8 m. It contained remains of seeds of the vetch plant, which served as fodder and medicine. On the eastern side of the building were two rooms, the northern lower than the southern and containing a curved staircase carved out of bedrock. In the northeastern corner of the room was an opening for ventilation to a cave on a lower level, which was



Rhyton in the form of a deer's head.



General view of the Persian period building.

entered from the east. In it was found a silver coin with the image of an owl and the symbol of the mint of the city of Gaza.



Achaemenian seal.

Also among the finds were an 8.5-cm-high square basalt altar, a rhyton in the form of a deer's head, and an Achaemenian stamp seal. On the basis of the pottery and the nature of the construction, two phases of the Persian period could be distinguished. In the first phase, ascribed to the sixth–fifth centuries BCE, a government building was erected on the site for the use of the administrators of the province. In the second phase, dating to the

fifth–fourth centuries BCE, the building was converted into an agricultural center, mainly for the manufacture of olive oil and textiles. The building was apparently destroyed during Alexander the Great's campaign in the last quarter of the fourth century BCE.

THE HERODIAN PERIOD. In the southernmost of the eastern row of rooms was a small stepped pool from the Herodian period. The finds from this period included a knife-shaped oil lamp decorated with two circles and parallel lines, and small delicate bowls with inverted rims. The site was apparently inhabited at this time by a temporary settlement of rebels or refugees who had fled Jerusalem during the First Jewish Revolt against Rome.

HANANYA HIZMI

JERICHO

An update to Vol. 2, pp. 674–697.

RENEWED EXCAVATIONS

Several short excavation seasons were conducted in 1998–2000 at the Second Temple period winter palaces in the area of Tulul Abu el-‘Alayiq in Jericho. The excavations were conducted by an expedition of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem under the direction of E. Netzer, with the assistance of Y. Kalman and R. Laureys-Chachy. The work concentrated upon the area east of the twin palaces, the area northeast of Herod's second palace, and the workshop area.

EXCAVATION RESULTS

THE OPEN-AIR TRICLINIUM. A broad U-shaped plastered couch or triclinium of the Hasmonean period, built in two phases, was exposed in the courtyard adjoining the eastern side of the twin palaces. A recess in one corner of the initial phase of this structure contained evidence for a tree root c. 70 cm in diameter, indicating that the triclinium was constructed in this spot to take advantage of a date palm or some other tree that provided

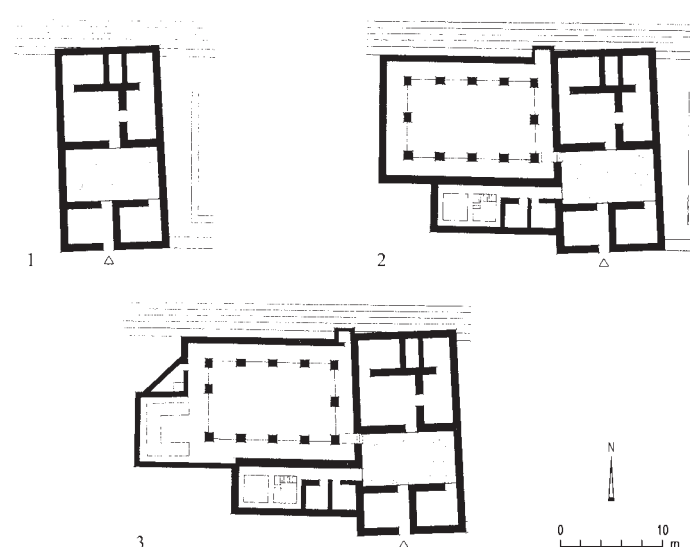
shade. The inner side of the couch bears remains of a fresco decoration. During its second phase the structure was extended to accommodate more diners.

THE SYNAGOGUE COMPLEX. Most of the main wing of the second palace was fully exposed, including the central part of its courtyard—the garden—elevated c. 80 cm above the surrounding colonnades. An outstanding discovery was made under the northeastern corner of this wing, where a synagogue complex from an earlier, Hasmonean, stage was revealed and fully excavated. The complex is located at the edge of a row of mostly unexcavated buildings, which extended from the Hasmonean palace complex to the workshop area, next to a branch of the Na‘aran aqueduct. Dated to the end of the reign of Alexander Jannaeus, these buildings apparently accommodated the administrators of the adjacent royal estate.

The complex was constructed in three phases. In the first phase, a building (c. 20 by 10 m) consisting of a small courtyard and seven rooms was constructed, probably as a dwelling. In the second phase, probably dur-



Synagogue hall, looking east; the staff and workers are seated on the edges of the aisles.



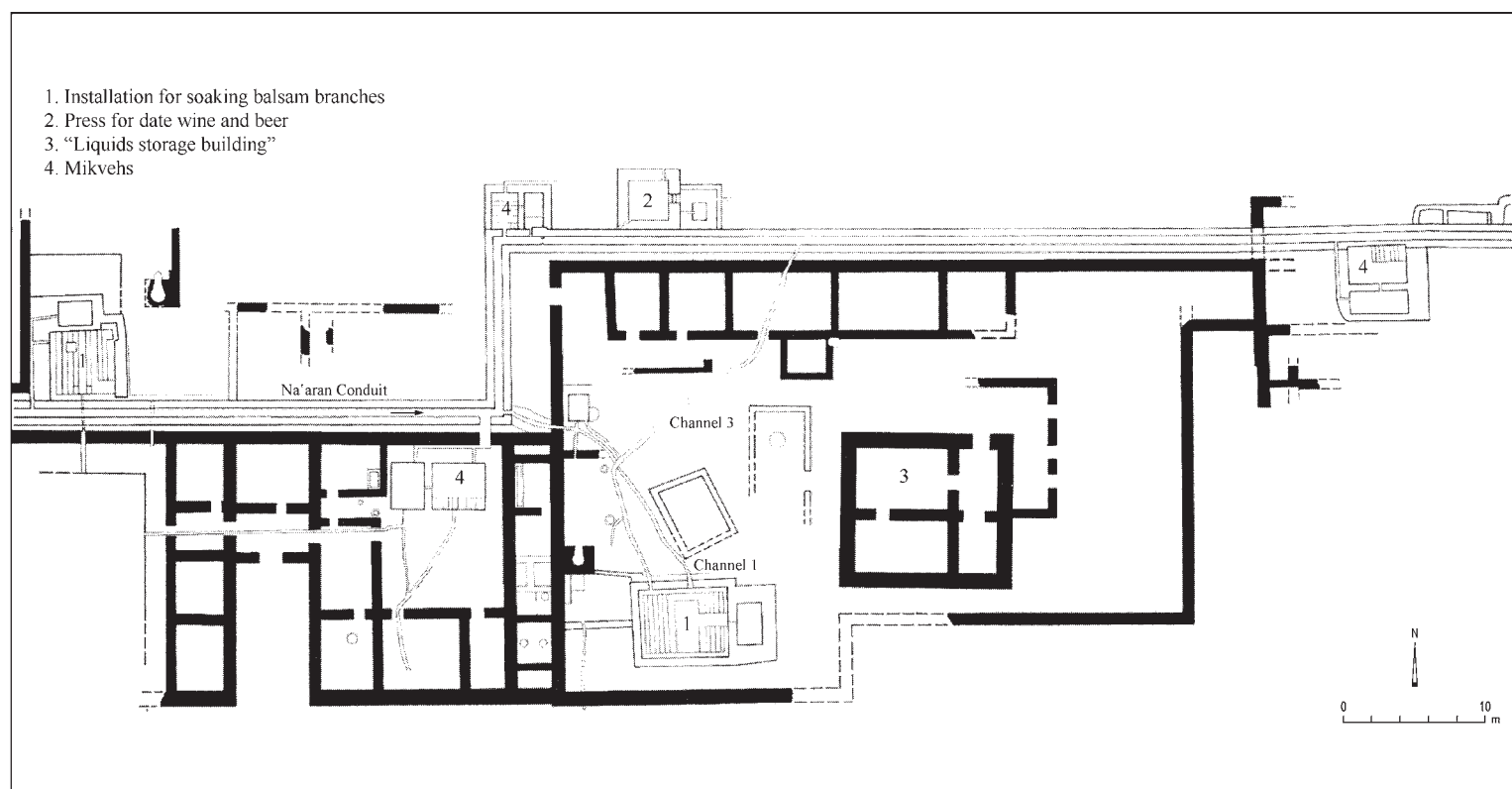
Three phases of the synagogue complex.

ing the reign of Queen Salome Alexandra (76–67 BCE), this building was turned into a synagogue, with the addition of a large hall (16.5 by 11.5 m) and a wing that included a mikveh. The hall was surrounded on all sides by pillars (c. 90 by 80 cm), 12 altogether, and the aisles were separated from the nave by low retaining walls, between the pillars, which functioned as benches. One additional bench was constructed in the western aisle, two others in the northern aisle. In all, the synagogue hall contained some 140 seats.

The hall was equipped with two interesting features. One is a niche with a two-level, built-in cupboard located at its northeastern corner. The niche included a compartment with a narrow opening, apparently intended to hold the Torah scrolls, and under it a tiny compartment, below the level of the aisles, probably to be used as a genizah. The second feature of the hall is a basin, perhaps for the ritual washing of hands, incorporated into the benches of the northern aisle. It was attached to a narrow channel, which began at the Na'aran aqueduct, and continued under the hall floor into the mikveh. The mikveh contained two pools, one for immersion and the other for stored water (the *otzar*). Two small rooms, apparently used for washing, were exposed next to the mikveh.



Installation for soaking balsam branches.



General plan of the workshop area during Herod's reign.

The major change in the third phase was the addition of two rooms, a large one (6.4 by 4.7 m) that opened onto the western side of the hall, and a second small one, which was triangular in shape. A U-shaped wide couch—a triclinium—occupied the large room, whereas the small room probably functioned as a kitchen. Worthy of note is the dismantling of the southwestern corner of the synagogue hall, necessitated by this addition, and the shifting of the central western pillar, so as not to be an obstruction between the audience in the hall and those dining in the triclinium. Noteworthy is the physical proximity of this triclinium and the open-air triclinium described above, only 60 m apart, as well as their approximate contemporaneity.

Architecturally, the synagogue resembles that of Gamala, which is dated to the beginning of the first century CE. Jericho's synagogue, as a whole, corresponds to information from literary sources concerning the role of the synagogue during the Second Temple period, when it served as a place for reading and studying scripture, settling disputes, accommodating guests, and community gatherings. The presence of the mikveh and triclinium within the synagogue of the period are also attested by these sources.

THE WORKSHOP AREA. The renewed excavations further explored the workshop area, offering a better understanding of the function of its main installations. Two of these were probably connected with the cultivation of balsam. Each installation contained paved floors, two adjacent pools, and stoves. The basalm branches were apparently crushed upon the paved floors. The two adjacent pools were connected at their bottom, one with stairs on two opposite sides, the other without stairs. They appear to have been used for soaking the crushed balsam branches. Pliny describes the use of branches to provide more of the precious raw balsam (*NH* XII. LIV, 118). The stoves were apparently for the distillation in cauldrons of the liquid produced by the soaking process. The liquids that were processed in these installations were probably stored in the "liquids storage building." The workshop area also included several mikvehs and a press for the processing of date wine and beer, and probably also of date honey, one of several exposed around the royal estate.

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